

Incident Response Guide

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1. Purpose

This document defines how the engineering team detects, triages, and resolves production incidents.

2. Severity Levels

Level	Definition
SEV-1	Full outage or critical data integrity issue affecting all customers. Immediate response.
SEV-2	Significant degradation affecting a subset of customers or a core feature.
SEV-3	Minor issue with limited customer impact; can be scheduled into normal work.

3. Response Process

- Detection — Alert fires via monitoring or is reported by a customer/internal user.
- Triage — The on-call engineer acknowledges the alert within 5 minutes (SEV-1) and assesses severity.
- Declaration — For SEV-1/SEV-2, the on-call engineer declares an incident and pages the incident commander.
- Mitigation — Focus on restoring service first before root-causing.
- Resolution — Confirm recovery via dashboards and close the incident.
- Postmortem — A blameless postmortem is required for all SEV-1 and SEV-2 incidents within 3 business days.

4. Roles

- On-call engineer: first responder, owns initial triage and mitigation.
- Incident commander: coordinates response, communication, and stakeholder updates during SEV-1 incidents.
- Communications lead: responsible for customer-facing status page updates during major incidents.

5. Escalation

If unresolved within 30 minutes for a SEV-1, escalate to the Engineering Manager and, if needed, the VP of Engineering. External vendor escalations should be initiated in parallel with internal mitigation, not sequentially.

6. Postmortem Requirements

Postmortems must include: timeline, root cause, impact, what went well, what went poorly, and concrete follow-up action items with owners and due dates.

7. Access During Incidents

Temporary elevated access granted during an incident must be logged and automatically revoked within 24 hours of incident closure.